

Q (Post-trip question): How would you define your entire trip to India? Who did you meet, and what's the final impression that you're taking away?

Though Ingres Corporation's CEO has been visiting India almost every year, this was my first trip to this country. I found the market to be a fertile ground for open source where the customers are smart and demanding, and want to pay for the value they receive. We met with customers and partners, and our take away was that we needed to further expand upon our presence in this market.

Q What has India's role been so far in the overall scheme of things for Ingres?

India is a high growth strategic market for Ingres where we are increasing our investments based on the rapid adoption we have seen in the last couple of years. We now have customers in India adopting Ingres for some very interesting and innovative mission critical applications in the areas of custom applications, portals, workflow, content management systems, etc. India is also home to some of our global systems integration partners who have now established Ingres technology practices, and most of them are now involved in delivering large local as well as global projects on Ingres, from India.

Q Are there any changes in your strategy, with respect to India?

Even though open source as a market and Ingres as a company are seeing worldwide growth, due to the continuing slowdown in IT spending across western economies, we are actually ratcheting up investments in select high growth geographies, and India is definitely a priority in that segment. So yes, the change is to re-affirm the commitment to this market and increase the investments in India.

Q Can you share details about further investments in India—what are the areas you are investing in, and what are your short term expectations from these investments?

We are investing in India by hiring local technical as well as sales and marketing resources in multiple locations, so that our customers and partners have easy access to us. We are also rolling out our ISV recruitment campaign in India, which has already been very successful, especially in Europe. The expectation is to grow our sales and marketing operations in India ahead of most regions. We are also considering India for our engineering operations and have started recruiting in this area.

Q What is your view on how much open source databases are used, compared to the overall database usage in Indian businesses?

Eighty per cent of the enterprise database market runs on Oracle, globally, and the scenario is similar in India. This monopoly situation could be because of Oracle's single sourcing strategy—when only one vendor provides the majority of products such as the database, the OS, middleware, etc, for an entire project. But in the last few years, we have seen that

many customers find that they do not like a scenario of over-dependence on a single vendor, in terms of achieving a balanced negotiating position. Vendor lock-in, wherein they lose the choice to experiment with other products that offer either better value for money or innovation, is becoming a significant issue. This is where we see customers deliberately deciding to introduce an open source technology alternative into their enterprise.

Indian enterprises, including the government, are now adopting open source solutions for mission critical projects, whereas as recently as just a couple of years ago, only peripheral/non-critical applications were considered for open source. This has been a big change and will allow customers to realise very significant cost savings in their IT infrastructure.

Q What is the revenue model of Ingres products? Are they based purely on socket-based licensing?

Ingres' success is defined by its ability to provide first class global support services. This aligns us very well with our customers' values. They want to pay for only the software they use, as they use it, as opposed to large upfront capital investments. Yet they expect the software and services to support the business. We charge on a CPU basis rather than the core, as some of our competitors do. And for those customers that want it, we are also able to provide an indemnity for potential IP violations as part of the support subscription, as Ingres does own the IP for our enterprise code base. Customers are free to use the community version of our software under GPL licensing and we encourage this where enterprise support is not necessary. The majority of Ingres' customers do pay for support as they are running business critical systems on our technology. This differentiates us from other OSS DBMS providers.

Q Is yours a dual licensing model like (MySQL) or is it simpler?

Ingres is an open source database and our revenue model is simple. We have a free community edition and a paid enterprise edition, where one pays a subscription fee for annual support. If you opt for the community edition, you will have to manage support-related issues like patch updates yourself, but if you get the paid enterprise edition, we do that for you as well as provide you with indemnity coverage, binary certifications across a lot of interfacing technologies and 24x7 support.

Q If I were to copy the enterprise version of Ingres and install it on my server—knowing fully well that I will not get any support from you—would that be a legal violation?

Yes, that would be a legal violation. If you want access and use of the Ingres technologies, and do not feel the need for support services, you can download the community version and stay within the law.

Q Yet, you tout Ingres as a leader in the open source space. How would you justify such an action, for an open source product?

The open source market has been evolving over the past few years. There is a highly skilled core of the RDBMS